

No. 3

Teletype message by Federal Chancellor, Brandt, to the President of the United States of America, Nixon

4 August 1973

AdsD, WBA, A 9, 20.

Published in: Berliner Ausgabe, vol. 6.

English translation: Dwight E. Langston

Dear Mr. President,

Thank you for your teletype message of 30 July.¹

Even with all the difficulties we face, it is nevertheless advantageous to find ourselves engaged in consultations intended to strengthen the Alliance and delineate the relationship between the United States and Western Europe in its process of unification. When the United States seized the initiative to declare the year 1973 as the year of Europe and to define the new relationship between Americans and Western Europeans², there had in fact been no preparatory consultations on the matter.

I see a correlation between the opinion – shared by me – that an Atlantic declaration must have substance and the necessity of allowing all participants sufficient time for deliberations, consultations and decisions.

In the discussions which we conducted in late April and early May³, I advocated the position that the United States should, for the common interest, act as if the European Community had already achieved a more definitive structure. The Nine are presently in a very difficult phase of learning how they can, in spite of extant national interests, find a common course in significant policy issues.

I can understand that you find certain aspects of this learning process burdensome, *i.e.* the expenditure of time involved. But I do not believe that the United States, which for such a long time has advocated that Europe speak with one voice, should mistakenly feel excluded when the Nine strive to find unity among themselves.

I am convinced, and would like to emphasize strongly, that through this process nothing has changed with respect to the feeling of solidarity and kindred interests in the area of security between European and American partners in the Atlantic Alliance.

Incidentally, I am of the opinion that the time until mid-September will not be wasted at all. After a successful conclusion of discussions among the Nine, the United States will not have to speak with instructed representatives⁴ and, most certainly, not in terms of confrontation. Now it is much more a matter of defining, in terms of previous American wishes, what the Europeans really want. In other words, the working papers drafted by your government should be attached to a working paper drafted by the European governments.

I have complete understanding for your position that you first want to be familiar with the results of European opinion-making before you communicate any further course of action. Now, as before, I am of the opinion that, given the imminent major East-West conferences and after the historical visit of Brezhnev to the USA,⁵ a summit conference of NATO countries this year would be appropriate. An official initiative by the American President suggesting a summit conference to the Alliance would have my unequivocal support. The results of such a meeting should go beyond a mere communiqué; it should serve the purpose of adopting an Atlantic Declaration.

Furthermore, Mr. President, I wish to emphasize that you, regardless of the framework of other meetings, are always welcome in Bonn and Berlin.

At present it is hardly foreseeable in which framework a meeting with the Nine can take place. The various possible structures have been discussed in Washington and in Copenhagen. At present, only a combined meeting of NATO and EC countries appears to be out of the question, since Ireland at least will reject this for understandable reasons.⁶

As of today it is also still not possible to resolve the question as to which kind of statement a meeting between the Community and the American President should conclude with. However – provided an extensive Atlantic Declaration were to exist, I would then prefer a communiqué. At the same time, I am mindful that the EC/USA's problems are, in part, very complicated, so that decisions about solutions are hardly to be expected this year. What we want to avert is a European-American dispute which

becomes public. Therefore, I prefer a more modest common denominator to an ambitious, but controversial project.

I share your opinion that there should be no misunderstandings between us, and have, for that reason, replied to you at length.

Yours truly,

Willy Brandt

¹ Cf. No. 77.

² Cf. *ibid.*, Note 3.

³ Brandt visited the USA from 29 April to 3 May 1973. Cf. No. 72.

⁴ Cf. No. 77.

⁵ Meant here are the initial meeting of the CSCE at the Foreign Minister level from 3 to 8 July 1973 in Helsinki and also the beginning of the MBFR negotiations in Vienna on 30 October 1973. Brezhnev visited the USA from 18 to 25 June 1973. Cf. AdG 43 (1973), p. 17992 ff.

⁶ EC member Ireland did not belong to NATO.